She didn’t believe Akbar had killed her son. It was another visitor who told her. Pale but composed, Maham went to Akbar and asked if she might see Adham one last time. Already, his mangled body had been inspected on behalf of the ataka khail, Shamsuddin’s brothers and sons threatening civil war unless they were avenged. Akbar made sure they were satisfied; but he wouldn’t let Maham near the body.

Perhaps he was trying to protect her – just as she had, perhaps, protected him on the ramparts of Kabul, or against the machinations of Bairam Khan. He could hardly protect her from her own grief. Forty days later, she died.

When he heard that Maham was gone, writes Abul Fazl, Akbar cried.

. Victoria and Albert Museum: https://collections.vam.ac.uk/item/O9289/akbar-and-abdur-rahim-painting-anant

. Abu’l Fazl, *The History of Akbar*, vol. 5, trans. W.M. Thackston (Murty Classical Library of India, Harvard University Press, 2019). The fact may have distressed the loyal historian, who makes at least one passing remark about ‘the lack of wisdom that often afflicts unbalanced tall people’ (*The History of Akbar*, vol. 2).

. Fr. Antonio Monserrate, *The Commentary of Father Monserrate, S.J. on his Journey to the Court of Akbar*, trans. J.S. Hoyland, annotations S.N. Banerjee (Oxford University Press, 1922).

. Baz Bahadur, ‘the most accomplished man of his day in the science of music and in Hindi song’, according to Nizamuddin, is said to have learnt music from Muhammad Adil, the Suri king who spotted Hemu’s military talent, and also tutored the legendary Tansen. If that is true, the Afghan king left behind a remarkable cultural legacy, if no trace of his short-lived dynasty. See Nizamuddin Ahmad, ‘Tabakat-i Akbari’, in *The History of India, As Told by Its Own Historians*, trans. H.M. Elliot, vol. 5 (Trübner and Co., 1873), and Vincent A. Smith, *Akbar the Great Mogul, 1542–1605* (Clarendon Press, 1917).

. Abu’l Fazl, *The Akbarnama of Abu’l Fazl* (completed by Inayatullah), vol. 2, trans. Henry Beveridge (first published 1902–1939; Low Price Publications, 2017).

. Nizamuddin Ahmad, *Tabakat-i Akbari*.

. Michael H. Fisher, *A Short History of the Mughal Empire* (I.B. Tauris, 2016).

. Abdul Qadir Badauni, *Muntakhab-ut-Tawarikh* (Selections from Histories), vol. 2, trans. W.H. Lowe (first published 1884–98; Atlantic Publishers and Distributors, 1990).

. ‘[I]n accordance with the Indian custom’ (*The Akbarnama of Abu’l Fazl*, vol. 2).

. Ibid.

. Iqtidar Alam Khan, *The Political Biography of a Mughal Noble: Mun’im Khan Khan-i Khanan, 1497–1575* (Orient Longman, 1973).

. Ibid.

. *The Akbarnama of Abu’l Fazl*, vol. 2.

. Adham Khan had been meaning to besiege a fortress nearby, in Gagraun, for a while, and this seemed a good day for it. Little did he know that Akbar had managed a quick and bloodless conquest of Gagraun on his gallop down to Sarangpur.

. *The Akbarnama of Abu’l Fazl*, vol. 2.

. Ibid.

. Ibid.

. Abu’l Fazl, *The History of Akbar*, vol. 3, trans. W.M. Thackston.